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The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo (1848)

Map of the US and Mexico BEFORE the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo:



The Treaty of Guadalupe is a critical document in the history of the United States. You may have heard Latinxs of Mexican roots in particular, in conversation about how this land (California, west, and southwest) **was** Mexico at one time. Indeed, the assertion is absolutely correct and the reality of that is an important part of our shared history.

In order to understand the Treaty and its impact more fully, let's first take some time to briefly review the Mexican-American War (1846-1848), which ended with the signing of the document in 1848. **Read and annotate the video below.** Material from this video will appear in the module quiz.

Below we focus on the Mexican-American War Explained in 17 Minutes!

Pay special attention to the material on the Treaty of Guadalupe-Hidalgo to help contextualize our reading and analysis of the Treaty coming up. Take good notes, particularly if you are unfamiliar with this bit of history.

(17 minutes)



The Mexican-American War - Explained in 16 minu

Knowledgeia



Watch on

With the annexation of more than 525,000 square miles of land, the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo extended the boundaries of the United States west to the Pacific Ocean. This agreement, along with the 1853 Gadsen Purchase, created the southern border of the present-day United States.

Impact

"On February 2, 1848, the United States and Mexico signed the treaty of Guadalupe-Hidalgo. In the Treaty, Mexico agreed to surrender all claims to Texas and accept the Rio Grande as the boundary of that state. Mexico also agreed to sell its New Mexico and Upper California territories to the United States at a price of \$15 million. The treaty effectively halved the size of Mexico and doubled the territory of the United States."

"This territorial exchange had long-term effects on both nations. The war and treaty extended the United States to the Pacific Ocean, and provided a bounty of ports, minerals, and natural resources for a growing country. The abundance of lands also produced debates about extending slavery into the West, a dispute that would help spark a nation-defining civil war. In Mexico, the loss of battles and territories was a national trauma. As political and military leaders challenged each other on the best way to revive their troubled country, Mexico also descended into a long period of turmoil, civil war, and foreign intervention. But the war also inspired new leaders who were determined to avoid additional humiliation for their country. The new generation eventually united Mexico, forced out foreign invaders, and established the foundations of a modern state."

"Perhaps the most enduring effect of the war, however, is on U.S.-Mexican relations. While the war is recalled with passion south of the border, it is often overlooked to the north. And, although the two countries have developed strong bonds and friendly ties since 1848, these neighbors continue to struggle with distrust and misunderstandings created by the war, its effects, and the differing approaches to remembering the conflict. "

Source: National Park Service

Annotation from on the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo:

"In early 1848, following the United States capture and occupation of Mexico City, negotiations drew up a preliminary draft of the treaty. After revision by the Senate, the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, signed in the Villa de Guadalupe across from the **shrine dedicated to Mexico's patron saint, the Virgin of Guadalupe**, was ratified by both governments later that year. In return for the northern third of Mexico, the United States agreed to pay **\$15 million** and to assume up to \$3.25 million in claims by its citizens against the Mexican government. The treaty guaranteed Mexicans newly absorbed into the United States and to their descendants certain political rights, including land rights." [That's about about 443 million dollars in today's dollar value].

"The Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo gave Mexicans the right to remain in United States territory or to move to Mexico. About three thousand chose to move, but the overwhelming majority decided to stay. These people could choose to retain Mexican citizenship or become citizens of the United States. [Instructor note: imagine, having to make that choice!] The treaty explicitly guaranteed Mexican Americans "the right to their property, language, and culture." The United States Senate revised Article IX, which guaranteed Mexicans civil and political rights (substituting wording from the treaty acquiring Louisiana territory from France), and deleted Article X, which protected Mexican land grants. Officials feared that Article X would revive old Mexican and Spanish land grants and would have thrown into question land grants made by the Texas government following its declaration of independence in 1836. Many Mexicans did not have perfect title to their lands. Frequent changes in political administrations, the slowness of the Mexican bureaucracy made it difficult for landholders to obtain clear title. Article X would have allowed them to complete the process under administration by the United States. The article specifically recognized the rights of Mexican land-grant claimants in Texas, most of whom had been dispossessed of their lands by Anglo-Texans

following Texas independence. The article would have allowed them to resurrect their claims and fulfill the conditions of Mexican law."

Source: [Digital History](https://www.digitalhistory.uh.edu/disp_textbook.cfm?smtID=3&psid=1141) https://www.digitalhistory.uh.edu/disp_textbook.cfm?smtID=3&psid=1141 (site is maintained by the University of Houston)

